

Chapter 149-1

The stairwell was so quiet that you could hear the wind outside the window, scraping past mercilessly with a deafening sound.

The woman's skin was honey-colored, and those eyes were extremely sharp. The true red lipstick on her lips was exceptionally sexy.

Gu Yixue wasn't as tall as her. Her back was pressed against the cold wall, the corners of her eyes tinged with an unusual flush, and the strong smell of alcohol emanated from her body.

"How much did you drink?" The woman frowned and asked coldly.

"Want to know?" Gu Yixue raised an eyebrow and curved her lips into a smile. "Kiss me once, and I'll tell you."

The woman frowned and called out her name sternly: "Gu! Yi! Xue!"

Gu Yixue's hand fell on her shoulder. "What? Jiejie, call me something else."

The woman took a step forward, getting closer to her, her words full of warning: "Don't push your luck."

Gu Yixue's hand had already wrapped around to the back of her neck. "Then what should I do? I love you so much I'm going crazy. What do you want me to do?"

Gu Yixue stood on tiptoe, slowly leaning in, gently closing her eyes, her eyelashes trembling slightly.

Lips met lips.

Gu Yixue's somewhat pale lips were stained with the woman's lipstick, looking even prettier than before.

The woman's hand braced against the wall clenched into a fist. She called out her name again: "Gu Yixue, you can't do this."

"Then what should I do?" Gu Yixue's throat moved slightly. "Feng He-jiejie, you like me too, don't you?"

"I'm engaged to Gu Chunmian." Shen Fenghe withdrew her arm and took half a step back, standing coldly across from Gu Yixue. "You should know that. I can't touch you."

"But what if I insist on touching you?" Gu Yixue looked at her, raising her hand to rest beneath her eyelashes. "You like me, right?"

"You're just my sis—" Shen Fenghe said coldly.

"But you wouldn't kiss Shen Hui either." Gu Yixue interrupted her. "Have you ever been like this with Shen Hui? She's your real sister."

"Gu Yixue!" Shen Fenghe frowned. "Do you know what you're saying?"

"I do." Gu Yixue curved her lips into a smile—a miserable smile. "I'm an illegitimate daughter, and I'm also a Beta, so I'm not worthy of you, Miss Shen. I can't compare to Gu Chunmian. You two are the proper engaged couple. But what can I do?"

Gu Yixue moved closer to her. When Shen Fenghe tried to step back, Gu Yixue's hand wrapped around her waist, standing on tiptoe slightly to meet Shen Fenghe's eyes. "What do you want me to do when I love you this much? Miss Shen."

As she said those last five characters, Gu Yixue's voice was trembling, tears threatening to fall but not yet falling, all pooled in her eyes.

Shen Fenghe stood unmoving, her expression cold. "So what?"

Gu Yixue leaned in, raising her slender white neck, her long hair falling down, moving forward to kiss Shen Fenghe. Her voice was muddled: "Just let me use the alcohol as an excuse to kiss you, okay? Jiejie~"

Said carefully yet brooking no refusal.

Shen Fenghe lowered her gaze, and at a glance she could see Gu Yixue's chest.

Her waist was so slender it could barely be grasped.

Yet she loved wearing crop tops. Even in winter, she only wore a black tight off-shoulder sweater, with a tattoo at her collarbone that was obscured by the straps, and black high-waisted wide-leg pants.

Her fair waist was exposed, and there was a patch of burn scars on her lower back.

But she had never thought to cover them.

Shen Fenghe didn't initiate, but she also didn't refuse.

It was only when Gu Yixue finished kissing her lips and wanted to go further that Shen Fenghe clenched her teeth shut.

Gu Yixue could only linger on her lips.

The passionate kiss belonged only to Gu Yixue. Shen Fenghe was so cold it was as if Gu Yixue was kissing someone else entirely—not a single reaction.

Gu Yixue kissed until her own eyes brimmed with hot tears, tears trailing down the side of her face.

She also smeared Shen Fenghe's lipstick.

That vibrant red had been smudged to the corners of her lips and the side of her face, making Shen Fenghe's makeup look somewhat strange.

Shen Fenghe just watched her coldly, letting her do as she pleased.

A kiss without a response had no meaning.

Gu Yixue stopped, smiling bitterly: "Jiejie, when you kiss and make love to Gu Chunmian, are you like this too?"

Shen Fenghe raised her hand to wipe the corner of her lips, getting a hand full of red. She lowered her gaze and said coldly: "What does that have to do with you?"

Gu Yixue paused. "You're right, it has nothing to do with me."

A few seconds later, Gu Yixue continued: "But I want to know."

She looked into Shen Fenghe's cold eyes. "I want to know just how much you love Gu Chunmian."

Shen Fenghe said: "None of your business."

"Really?" Gu Yixue raised an eyebrow flippantly. "Gu Chunmian is shoving her little mistress into my crew."

Shen Fenghe still showed no reaction. She found a tissue from inside her suit jacket and wiped the lipstick that had been smeared by the kiss.

"Jiejie, do you need me to teach her a lesson?" Gu Yixue asked.

Shen Fenghe stared at her, her brow furrowing even tighter. "Gu Yixue, you're almost thirty, not thirteen."

"So what?" Gu Yixue was taken aback. "Then do you love Gu Chunmian? Answer me."

Shen Fenghe's answer remained the same: "None of your business."

"Then when you two make love, does it feel good?" Gu Yixue asked.

Shen Fenghe froze for a moment. "You go abroad for a few years and now you talk about these things so casually? Marriage doesn't require love. Even if I don't love Gu Chunmian, I don't love you either."

Gu Yixue gazed at those cold eyes, lightly licked her lips, and suddenly changed the subject. "But jie's lipstick tastes really good."

Shen Fenghe pressed her lips together. Looking at Gu Yixue's fair waist and abdomen, she took off her suit jacket and tossed it to her. "Go home early."

Shen Fenghe was left with only a thin shirt, her black tie tied neatly.

She was about to leave after speaking, but Gu Yixue grabbed her tie and pulled her back.

Shen Fenghe stared at her impatiently. "Still want to make a scene?"

Gu Yixue leaned against the wall, her fair hand moving up along the tie bit by bit until it stopped at the collar. She looked as aggrieved as a whimpering stray dog on the roadside. "Jiejie, kiss me. If you kiss me, I'll stop making a scene, okay?"

"Otherwise..." Gu Yixue licked her lips. "I'll go to your house tonight and make a scene, saying I want to marry you..."

Before she could finish, Shen Fenghe braced one arm against the wall and kissed her forcefully.

In an instant, all of Gu Yixue's breath was stolen away.

Gu Yixue's head hit the cold wall, and she could barely breathe.

It was a kiss so dominating it was suffocating.

Shen Fenghe didn't do anything, yet she made Gu Yixue cry.

Tears clung to her eyelashes, making her look pitiful and delicate.

After a long while, Shen Fenghe straightened up. Gu Yixue's lips were numb, and she could barely stand steady.

But Shen Fenghe didn't have such an intense reaction. Her gaze and expression remained cold.

"Gu Yixue." Shen Fenghe looked at her coldly. "Stop being crazy."

Gu Yixue leaned against the wall. "If jiejie kisses me, I won't go crazy."

Hearing this, Shen Fenghe glanced at her, then turned and left.

The sound of the door closing echoed in the stairwell. The voice-activated light was dim and yellow. Gu Yixue's fingertips fell on her own lips, lightly brushing over her somewhat numb lips.

Then she raised her hand to wipe away her tears, revealing a smile completely at odds with before.

That smile concealed something cold.

She was wearing Shen Fenghe's suit jacket, which still carried Shen Fenghe's scent.

Gu Yixue lowered her head and sniffed lightly. It was a scent she liked. Then she left a kiss on the jacket—a faint red mark.

She clearly likes me, Gu Yixue thought.

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When Gu Yixue returned to the private room, she had an extra suit jacket on. Her hair was also down now—no longer the high ponytail from before, but all loosened, long enough to cover her shoulder blades.

But her expression was still the same as before, a smile carrying a hint of coldness.

While waiting for everyone to finish eating, she lit a cigarette, stood by the window to finish smoking, then returned to the table and asked the two young girls, Qi Tang and Tang Zui: "Are you full?"

The two young girls nodded: "We're full."

Then the group went downstairs, and Gu Yixue went to the counter to pay.

While going downstairs, Liang Shi noticed a woman in a white shirt on the first floor whose gaze swept toward them.

The woman's pupils were very beautiful, but those eyes were too sharp, emanating a powerful pressure.

Sitting across from her was a girl wearing a purple sweater and a tulle skirt, who looked gentle and serene—forming a stark contrast with her.

Liang Shi only glanced casually before quickly looking away.

Gu Yixue finished paying, and then they heard someone call out: "Xiao Xue."

The group all turned around at once, looking toward the source of the voice.

Liang Shi saw the girl in the purple sweater walking toward them, with the woman in the white shirt following closely behind.

Gu Yixue saw the woman in purple and nodded with a smile: "Xiaoxiao-jie."

Distant yet polite.

"It really is you." Kong Xiaoxiao smiled and patted her shoulder. "I thought it looked like you... Hey, isn't that Fenghe's jacket you're wearing? Looks like you two already ran into each other."

Gu Yixue glanced at Shen Fenghe. Shen Fenghe was looking down and poking at her phone, not making eye contact with her at all.

Gu Yixue said: "Mm, we ran into each other in the restroom just now. Fenghe-jie saw I was too cold, so she lent me her jacket."

"I see." Kong Xiaoxiao said with feeling. "It's been years since we last met."

"I've been abroad for several years." Gu Yixue said. "I just came back not long ago. I haven't really been back much."

"Then we should get together often from now on. I've seen your films—you really live up to being Gu Yixue, you really know how to shoot." Kong Xiaoxiao praised. "Last time when Fenghe and I watched together, she even praised you."

Shen Fenghe finished what she was doing. Hearing this, she frowned and glanced at her friend: "When did we watch it?"

But Gu Yixue smiled and said: "Thank you for Fenghe-jie's praise."

"I praised you too. How come you're not thanking me?" Kong Xiaoxiao said, as if seeking a reward.

Gu Yixue paused briefly: "Thank you too, Xiaoxiao-jie."

As she spoke, Gu Yixue went to pay for their table's bill, but Kong Xiaoxiao stopped her: "How can I let you, a little sister, pay? I'll get it."

"It's fine." Gu Yixue had already finished paying. Then she glanced at Shen Fenghe: "Consider it my treat. Next time you and Fenghe-jie can treat me back."

When she said "Fenghe-jie," there was somehow a hint of something suggestive in it.

But Shen Fenghe remained expressionless from start to finish, standing there like a cardboard cutout.

Kong Xiaoxiao exchanged a few more pleasantries with Gu Yixue before the group finally left.

After they left, Kong Xiaoxiao and Shen Fenghe also grabbed their things and headed out. "Ah, time really flies. Back then Gu Yixue was just a little bean sprout, and in the blink of an eye she's become an internationally renowned director. Isn't she younger than Shen Hui?"

"No." Shen Fenghe said. "She's a year older than A-Hui."

"So she's younger than us by..." Kong Xiaoxiao hesitated for a few seconds before calculating. "Six years."

"Mm." Shen Fenghe nodded and put on her coat.

Kong Xiaoxiao sighed: "I still remember when she used to cry from being bullied by Gu Chunmian."

"That was so long ago." Shen Fenghe said. "You still remember."

"What? I can't talk about it just because Gu Chunmian is your fiancée?" Kong Xiaoxiao wrapped her scarf around herself. The two of them came out of the restaurant and stood on the street. Kong Xiaoxiao crossed her arms and watched the traffic, still reminiscing about childhood with Shen Fenghe. "If you ask me, Gu Chunmian has been a bastard since she was little. Back then she locked Gu Yixue in a closet for four days and nearly suffocated her to death. If you hadn't found her, Gu Yixue would have been a corpse."

"Oh right." Kong Xiaoxiao stamped her feet and breathed into her palms. "Has Gu Chunmian broken things off with that woman yet?"

"No." Shen Fenghe replied coldly.

Kong Xiaoxiao: "....."

"So are you two still getting married or not?" Kong Xiaoxiao asked.

Shen Fenghe paused, then answered: "Yes."

Kong Xiaoxiao: "....."

"Then why don't you step in and make Gu Chunmian break it off with that woman?" Kong Xiaoxiao understood matters of marriage alliances between prominent families, but she particularly looked down on this kind of behavior—already engaged yet still messing around outside. "Are you really going to let Gu Chunmian graze sheep on your head?"¹

Hearing this, Shen Fenghe furrowed her brow and walked toward the car. She happened to see Gu Yixue seeing off the young girls from her crew.

She put the girls into a taxi, paid for them, and even leaned into the car window to remind the driver to drive slowly.

She was quite thoughtful.

Shen Fenghe got into the car, and Kong Xiaoxiao followed.

From the rearview mirror, she could just see Gu Yixue standing under a tree chatting with a woman.

It was the one from inside the restaurant earlier.

Gu Yixue was dressed lightly, just wearing a wool coat over her suit jacket. The wind blew her clothes fluttering in the air, along with her hair.

She took out a cigarette and lit it, chatting with a faint, detached smile.

The scarlet cigarette tip flickered in the air.

Kong Xiaoxiao glanced over: "I heard the entertainment industry is pretty chaotic. I wonder if our Xiao Xue has picked up any bad habits?"

Shen Fenghe lowered her gaze and thought to herself: "She definitely has."

But in front of her, why was she still the same child who never grew up?

Always crying.

Kong Xiaoxiao sighed before remembering to continue asking Shen Fenghe: "You and Gu Chunmian are both not young anymore. If you're going to get married, shouldn't you hurry? Any later and she might be marrying you while pregnant with that woman's child. What? Are you going to raise someone else's kid?"

Shen Fenghe pressed her lips together and said flatly: "I'm not an idiot."

Kong Xiaoxiao: "....."

Shen Fenghe was feeling frustrated. She found a pack of cigarettes in the car, put one in her mouth, and lit it.

Her gaze fixed on the person standing under the tree, chatting and smoking. Her voice was very cold: "If I step in and break them up, won't Gu Chunmian raise hell with me?"

Kong Xiaoxiao: "Then what do you do?"

Shen Fenghe exhaled a ring of smoke: "Haven't figured it out yet. Let her family..."

She paused mid-sentence. The Gu family had long known that Gu Chunmian had a white moonlight, and had even had an abortion for the sake of that white moonlight.

Right now she still had the temporary mark² of her white moonlight on her body.

When it came time to marry Shen Fenghe, she would have to wash away the temporary mark.

But Gu Chunmian was favored in the Gu family, so no one in the family did anything about it. That's why she had been allowed to drag out this marriage for so many years.

It was only because her own father didn't concern himself with worldly matters, and her mother didn't interact much with the other ladies in their circle, that they didn't know about Gu Chunmian's messy affairs.

She had thought about breaking off the engagement before, but that happened to coincide with A-Hui's situation.

She had flown abroad overnight to bring A-Hui back. Seeing how low the mood was at home, she never brought it up again.

Now she couldn't be bothered anymore. She could afford to wait it out.

After all, she wasn't the one being tormented by this marriage.

Footnotes:

¹ "Graze sheep on your head" (在你腦袋上放羊): A Chinese idiom/slang meaning to be cuckolded or cheated on. The imagery suggests someone is treating your head like an open pasture—doing whatever they want with no regard for you.

² Temporary mark (臨時標記): In ABO dynamics, this refers to a marking that is not permanent, usually created during intimate moments. Unlike a permanent mark which bonds two people for life, a temporary mark fades over time and can be "washed away" or removed.

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Kong Xiaoxiao was frustrated: "If the Gu family could control Gu Chunmian, they wouldn't have let her lock little Yixue in a closet for four days. In the end, little Yixue nearly died, and Gu Chunmian? She didn't even get scolded once. It's only because little Yixue has such a good temperament that she didn't grow up twisted. Otherwise, she would have gone crazy long ago."

Shen Fenghe thought: She's pretty much there already.

Kong Xiaoxiao saw her lost in thought and assumed she was thinking about how to deal with the situation with Gu Chunmian, so she didn't interrupt. She watched Gu Yixue through the rearview mirror.

Gu Yixue had already put out her cigarette and was chatting happily with the woman across from her.

Only when Shen Fenghe came back to her senses did Kong Xiaoxiao say: "Is little Yixue dating someone?"

Shen Fenghe: "Huh?"

"That woman across from her—she's quite pretty." Kong Xiaoxiao said. "Oh right, she looks..."

Kong Xiaoxiao paused: "She looks a bit like you. Did you notice? Especially the eyes."

Shen Fenghe glanced over: "That person is married."

Kong Xiaoxiao was taken aback: "What? No way? Is little Yixue being a homewrecker?"

Shen Fenghe: "....."

"What's wrong with your brain?" Shen Fenghe was amused. "They're just in the same crew. She's an actress in her new production."

Kong Xiaoxiao: ".....Alright, you scared me."

Shen Fenghe stared at that person for a while, curling her fingers to tap lightly on the steering wheel: "How does she look like me?"

"The eyes." Kong Xiaoxiao said. "The color of your pupils is similar, and also the contours of your face. If you put her and Shen Hui in front of me and asked me to identify them, I might not even be able to recognize Shen Hui as your sister."

"Is it that extreme?" Shen Fenghe listened to her exaggerated description and looked a few more times, but still said: "Too bad. Shen Hui and I are biological sisters."

"I know. I just think it's fate." Kong Xiaoxiao said.

Shen Fenghe stubbed out her finished cigarette and waved her hand to disperse the smoke: "I do have another younger sister, actually."

Kong Xiaoxiao: "....."

Shen Fenghe said expressionlessly: "Too bad she's dead."

Kong Xiaoxiao: "....."

The car started and sped away.

Gu Yixue, who remained where she was, watched the red taillights of the departing car. Only then did she say to Liang Shi: "Let's go. Head home."

Liang Shi looked at her, then at the car speeding away.

She seemed to understand something.

But then Gu Yixue said: "Oh right, don't go thinking about tying people up. Things can easily go wrong."

Liang Shi: "?"